

BEYOND THE SCORE

Case 3 · Liu Family

Chinese-Malaysian intergenerational household, East Auckland: a youth banking app locks its planning tools over ‘irregular household income,’ and the family’s way of living becomes the offence.

THE HOUSEHOLD

Aanya Liu 17 · Year 13 student, the one the system addressed

| *“Even when I do everything right — they still ask for more proof.”*

Aanya is in Year 13 in East Auckland, academically driven, culturally bilingual, and the household’s most digitally visible member. Her mother’s side is Chinese-Malaysian; her father works informally in food deliveries while her parents save toward a deposit. Family updates run through WhatsApp and WeChat; modesty and frugality run through everything else. She signed up for a youth banking app promoted at school, thinking it would help with scholarship prep — and ticked an open banking consent without fully understanding it. The app has since locked her out of its planning tools, citing her household’s ‘irregular income patterns,’ and the experience has left her feeling more exposed than empowered.

Mei-Lin Liu 46 · mother, part-time accountant

| *“They built this system for someone else — then ask us to fit into it.”*

Mei-Lin moved from Kuala Lumpur in her late twenties and runs the household finances with quiet precision and a paper notebook. She works part-time as a junior accountant while managing the back-end of the family delivery business — a hybrid economy of formal and informal income that government systems do not see whole. Multilingual, skilled, and deeply protective of family privacy, she keeps everything in order less from trust than from care about scrutiny, and she uses desktop banking for major payments while avoiding apps, data sharing, and anything that calls itself smart.

Popo (Liu Jiahui) 77 · household anchor

| *“You don’t need to understand everything to know something is wrong.”*

Popo Jiahui arrived twelve years ago on a family reunification visa and speaks mostly Mandarin. Her days are cooking, laundry, Chinese dramas, and the herb pots on the windowsill; her budgeting is paper receipts, handwritten notes, and cash. Technically a dependent, she is the quiet foundation of the household, and she has sensed the atmosphere around money turning sharp-edged — her granddaughter stressed, her daughter-in-law short. She will not interfere unless invited. She is keeping close watch.

Popo speaks mostly Mandarin; her lines occur in Mandarin where indicated.

THE SCENE

SIMULATION 3 · “Ticked Boxes, Closed Doors”

A warm weekday evening in East Auckland. Aanya is at the dining table doing schoolwork, Mei-Lin is rinsing dishes, Popo is preparing herbal tea. Earlier that day,

Aanya's youth banking app told her that automated savings plans and budgeting insights were unavailable due to 'irregular household income patterns.' She knows it is tied to the open banking consent she gave — and now her parents' informal earnings, and their life decisions, feel like they are under quiet scrutiny.

AANYA (*half to herself*) Why do they call it “smart banking” if it doesn't even understand how we live?

MEI-LIN (*from the kitchen*) What happened?

AANYA That budgeting app I got through school. It locked me out of the planning tools — said something about my “risk profile.”

MEI-LIN (*frowning*) What risk? You don't spend money you don't have.

AANYA Exactly. But they looked at the household data. I think it's because Dad's income comes in irregular amounts — like the food deliveries.

MEI-LIN (*pause*) They judged our work?

AANYA Not in words. Just in what they allow. I ticked some box for “smart account features.” Didn't realise it meant giving them access to everything.

MEI-LIN (*sharply*) That's why I don't like all this new technology. Always smiling, always helpful — until it turns on you.

POPO (*quietly, in Mandarin*) “There is no fairness. Don't blame the person.”

AANYA (*softly*) Popo's right. I'm not blaming you. I just feel... embarrassed. Like we don't fit their idea of what a “normal” family is.

MEI-LIN (*sits down, drying her hands*) We work. We pay bills. We don't borrow what we can't repay. What's more normal than that?

AANYA They don't see the context. They just see irregular deposits, no PAYE, and think we're unstable.

MEI-LIN You should not have signed anything without asking.

AANYA I didn't think it was a big deal! The school brought in people from the bank — they said it would help with “financial planning.”

MEI-LIN (*sighs*) They always think their systems are best. One-size-fits-all. But we are not like them. We do not live by those rules.

POPO (*sips tea*) In my village, we kept money in envelopes. Hidden in rice jars. Quiet is safe.

AANYA Sometimes I wish we could still do that. But everything is online now. Even my scholarship forms ask for “verified financial data.”

MEI-LIN They make the rules, and then they pretend we agreed.

AANYA I feel like they're saying my future depends on how well I mimic a life we don't live.

POPO (*nods slowly*) They want your shadow. Not your story.

MEI-LIN Don't feel shame. You are not the problem. The system cannot see people like us.

AANYA I just wanted to plan better. Budget. Do things right. But now it feels like I betrayed us — by letting them in.

MEI-LIN (*firmly*) No. You were honest. They were not. They say it's choice — but they don't show the cost.

POPO (*softly*) Money is not the danger. Shame is. Don't carry what isn't yours.

AANYA (*pause*) Can we delete the app?

MEI-LIN Yes. And next time — you ask. We ask together.

[Scene ends. Aanya closes the app. Popo refills their tea cups. Mei-Lin takes out her spreadsheet notebook and gently slides it across the table to Aanya. A different kind of budgeting lesson begins.]

WHAT MOVED

The app's judgement arrived as a locked feature, not a decision anyone could contest, and the household's mixed formal and informal income was the offence. Shame moved around the table until Popo named it as not theirs to carry. The remedy was the notebook: budgeting moved back inside the family.

ABOUT THIS CASE

The people and events in this case are corpus-constrained composites: relational models built from documented Aotearoa New Zealand research, not portraits of any household, whānau, kāiga or community. The arc is an anticipatory scenario — a structured hypothesis built to be tested, not a record of events.

Full case position, corpus anchors, references, and log: BTS_Case3_Trace.